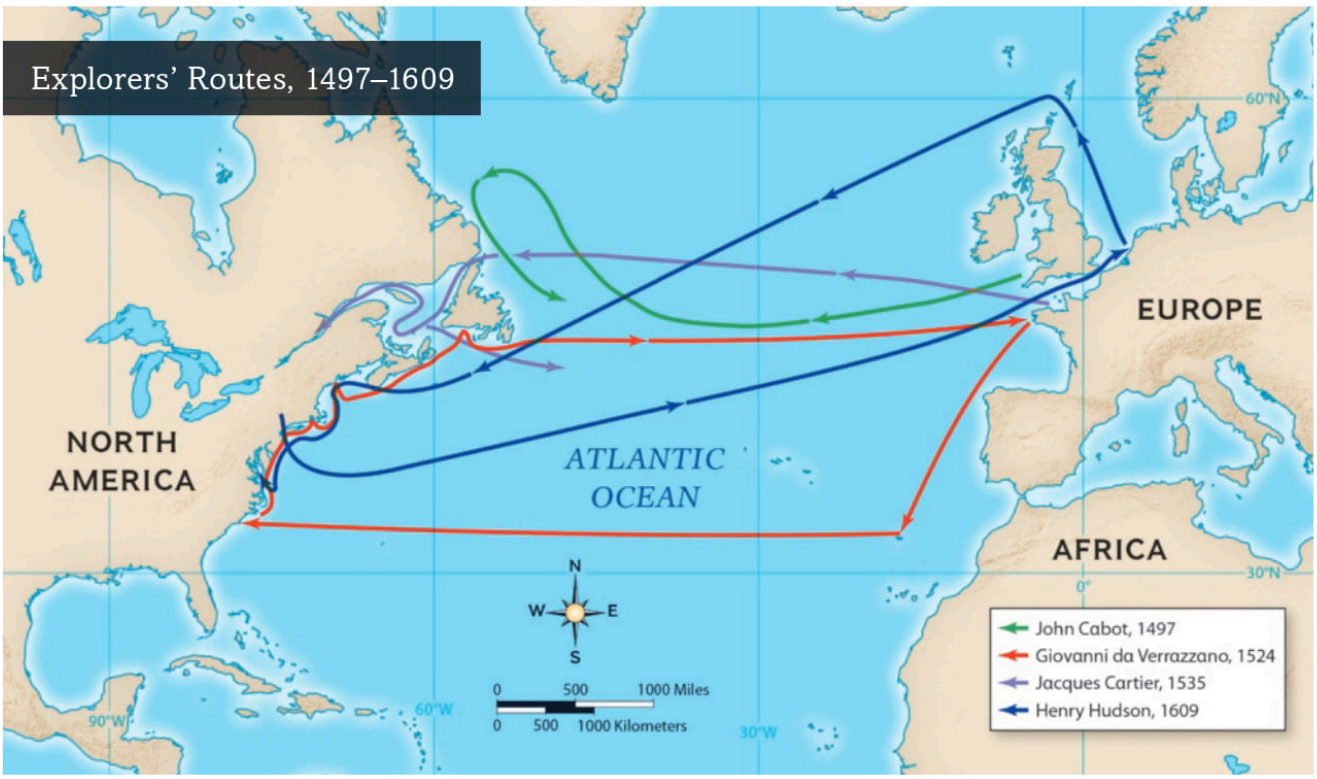
2.1 Competing Claims

You're probably used to friendly competitions in your classroom or among friends. For European countries in the 1500s, however, intense competition for land and resources in North America led to some not-so-friendly conflicts.

MAIN IDEA Struggles arose in Europe when other countries challenged the claims Spain and Portugal had made in the Americas.



THE NORTHWEST PASSAGE

European kings and queens hoped to find a water route to Asia through the Western Hemisphere. Several monarchs sent explorers to find such a route, or a **Northwest Passage**. In 1497, King Henry VII of England commissioned the Italian navigator **John Cabot**. Cabot left the harbor at Bristol, England, and sailed to Newfoundland, in present-day Canada, where he claimed land for the king. France sent another Italian, **Giovanni da Verrazzano**, to the Americas in January 1524. His ship *La Dauphine* landed near Cape Fear, North Carolina, and continued north along the coast to Newfoundland.

Ten years later, French seafarer **Jacques Cartier** explored the coast of Canada and the St. Lawrence River three different times. His interactions with the Native Americans there led to the name *Canada*. The name is derived from the Huron-Iroquois word *kanata*, meaning "village or settlement."

After voyaging to the Americas twice for England, an explorer named **Henry Hudson** made his final trip in 1609—this time for the Dutch in the Netherlands. Hudson sailed along the Atlantic coast after failing to navigate the Arctic Ocean. Today, a river, a strait, and a bay carry his name.

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Just as the conquistadors who searched for golden cities failed, none of these explorers found what they were looking for: a western route to Asia. However, the knowledge gained from these explorations did prove useful. It aided the countries when they later laid claim to land in North America.

TENSIONS GROW

While explorers searched for a Northwest Passage, religious and political unrest grew in Europe. The Spanish were already angry with the French and English for claiming lands in the New World. Tensions increased when France and England challenged Catholicism, the dominant faith in Spain.

As you have read, the Reformation began in 1517 when a German monk named Martin Luther accused the Catholic Church of corruption. At the time, Catholic priests were selling indulgences, which forgave sins in exchange for money. In response, Luther put together a document called the 95 Theses, which pointed out the Church's hypocritical and greedy practices. Luther's teachings divided European Christians, as some common people and rulers alike adopted his Protestant beliefs. Some of Luther's followers formed the branch of Protestantism that now bears his name: Lutheranism. The Catholic Church officially excluded him from Church rituals and membership. In addition, the Catholic Church **persecuted**, or punished, all followers of Protestantism.

One Protestant group, the French Huguenots, looked to the Americas for refuge. They tried settling in Brazil and South Carolina before founding a colony near St. Augustine, Florida, around 1564. This enraged Spain's **King Philip II**, but not only because he was Catholic. The Huguenots had chosen South Carolina with the intention of attacking Spanish ships carrying silver. It was not enough that they were **heretics**, or people who held beliefs different from teachings of the Catholic Church. Philip perceived them as a menace. The king sent General Pedro Menéndez de Avilés to remove the Huguenot colony. After a brief encounter at sea, Menéndez captured the French settlement at Fort Caroline. Most of the men who refused to return to Catholicism were killed.

The Cleveland Museum of Art, Cleveland

Looking at this gold, enamel, and citrine cameo, it may be hard to believe that King Philip II was actually in financial trouble during his reign. When he took the throne in 1556, he assumed the kingdom's debt. The debt only grew as Philip waged war after war and built a lavish palace. Eventually, Philip's spending would be a factor in the fall of the Spanish Empire.



King Philip II of Spain

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Spain's response to the claims of other European countries in North America?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Based on the sea routes shown on the map, which countries were likely competing over land claims in the Western Hemisphere?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did the Protestant Reformation influence European relations in the Americas?

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